



World Cup
2010

Cover Story



WORLD XI: Players to watch

Here are the top 11 players who could form a dream team

« **Lucio**
Centre Back,
Italy

« **Kaka**
Midfielder,
Brazil

Dani Alves
Wing Back, »
Brazil

Wayne Rooney »
Striker, England

» **Nemanja Vidic**
Centre Back,
Serbia

« **Lionel Messi**
Striker, Argentina

« **Xavi Alonso**
Midfielder,
Spain

« **Gianluigi Buffon**
Goalkeeper,
Italy

matches of qualification.

It could only have been this way because this is the first World Cup being played on this continent of conflict, across an expanse of high altitude in a country where the extreme is the routine. It is both poetic and perfect. Africa is where all of mankind came from, standing tall on two feet, walking the world and discovering dance. Then, a ball was added to the dance and men began to skim and skip over ground with shimmy and speed.

It is fitting. That football's most multi-coloured carnival will be held in South Africa, a free nation all of 16 years old. It is a moment of both youthful optimism and expectation which imagines a future that could bring impossible dreams to life.

In such heady times, it is no surprise then that seven of South Africa's 10 venues are in the high veld: from Rustenberg at 3,782 ft and Johannes-